



WEEK FIVE · MODULE THREE

The Mock Itinerary

One brief, nine days, five people, and everything that can go wrong

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This is the longest practice in the programme, and it is the one that most resembles the work itself.

You will be given a deliberately incomplete brief, because that is the only kind there is.

Take your time. This exercise, done properly, is a work sample you could show an agency.

CHAPTER I

How this week is practised

One brief, five exercises

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand the sequence and why it is in this order.

Exercise**What it trains**

- | | |
|------------------------------------|--|
| 1 · Complete the brief | Noticing what you were not told. This is the exercise most people rush, and it is the one that decides the other four. |
| 2 · The itinerary | Building a document a stranger could execute in your absence. |
| 3 · The budget | Operating a threshold, and presenting money without being asked. |
| 4 · Vetting | Choosing a supplier for the right reasons, in the right order. |
| 5 · The pre-mortem, and the crisis | Structured pessimism, and then a four-sentence escalation under time pressure. |

CHAPTER II

The brief

Exactly as you would receive it, which is to say, badly

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Read a real instruction, and notice what is missing.

THE INSTRUCTION, AS GIVEN

"We are going to Sardinia in August, the usual sort of thing, nine days. The Rossis are coming for part of it. Can you sort it out."

That is all you are given, and it was said while they were leaving the room, and they will not be available until Thursday.

What you know, from your preference file, because you have been keeping one:

- The household: the principal, his wife, three children (14, 11, 6), and a nanny who travels with them.
- They have been to Sardinia in August for six consecutive years, to the same villa, on the Costa Smeralda. The villa has been booked directly with the owner every year.
- The principal flies private on the outbound and, most years, commercial on the return, because he leaves later than the family.
- The wife does not like a full staff in the villa. Last year there was a cook who came at eleven and left at three, and it was mentioned, once, approvingly.
- The 6 year old has a serious nut allergy. It is recorded in your file exactly, and it is not approximate.
- The principal has, in each of the last two years, taken one day to Milan in the middle of the trip.
- The Rossis have four people, and they have never been before.
- Nobody has told you when in August.

CHAPTER III

Exercise one

Complete the brief

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Produce the questions before you produce anything else.

Before you book a single thing, write the questions you must ask, and separate them into three lists. This separation is the exercise.

List	What goes in it
Must ask, before I can do anything	The things where the whole plan changes. Usually two or three. If your list here is long, you have not thought hard enough about what you can infer.
Must ask, but not urgently	The things you need before you commit money, but that do not block you today. Ask them together, once, in one message, not in six.
Do not ask, infer	What your preference file already tells you. Every question in this column that you moved into the first column is a small failure of preparation, and every item you left here that you should have asked about is a much larger one.

Submit: the three lists, and one sentence under each item in the third column saying what your evidence is.

CHAPTER IV

Exercise two

Build the itinerary

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Produce a document a stranger could execute.

Now build the travel file. Assume the dates you were given after you asked. Assume the villa is confirmed.

The test of this document is not that it is complete. It is that a competent stranger could execute it if you were unreachable. Write it for that person.

It must contain	Specifically
Every leg	Outbound and return, for the family, for the principal, for the nanny, and for the Rossis if you are handling them, and you must decide whether you are, and justify it.
Leave times, not departure times	For every movement. The time they walk out of the door.
The ground	Every car, with a named person and a number at both ends. And the second option for each.
The arrival standard	What is in the villa before they walk in. Who put it there. When. This is the section that separates a booking from an arrival.
The allergy	How it is handled, with whom, in writing, at every point where food is prepared or served. Do not be brief here. Be exactly as thorough as the situation deserves, which is very.
The Milan day	He has taken it twice. He has not mentioned it. Decide what you do about that, and be able to defend your decision, because there are two defensible answers and one indefensible one.
The contingencies	One line each. Flight delayed. Bag lost. Car does not arrive. Someone is ill. A guest extends.
The one-page version	Everything above, compressed to a single page that fits in a pocket. If you cannot do this, the plan is too complicated.

CHAPTER V

Exercise three

The budget

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Build and present a budget without being asked to.

You have not been given a budget. You have not been given a threshold. This is normal, and it is the most common condition of the work.

Produce a one-page budget with the categories, the estimate for each, and the total. Then, at the foot of it, write the two sentences you will send with it.

- **The estimate, by category.** Villa, flights, ground, provisions, the cook, activities, contingency. The contingency is a line, and it is stated, and it is usually ten per cent.
- **The two or three decisions that are theirs.** Not a list of options. The specific places where money and preference intersect and where it would be presumption for you to choose.
- **The question about the threshold,** written the way you would actually write it, once, professionally, without apologising for asking.

CHAPTER VI

Exercise four

Vet a supplier

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Vet in the correct order, and reject for the correct reason.

You need a cook for the villa: eleven to three, six days a week, nine days, in a house with a child with a serious nut allergy and a family that values their privacy above almost everything.

You have three candidates.

Candidate	What you know
A	Recommended by the villa owner. Has cooked in that villa for four summers. Excellent, by all accounts. Mentions, in your first call, and warmly, the name of a family he cooked for last month, whom you have heard of.
B	Found through an agency. Insured, contracted, will sign anything. Good but unremarkable references. Twice the price of A. Has never worked in that villa. Asks you, in the first call, what the allergy protocol is and who else will be in the kitchen.
C	Recommended by another estate manager you trust, who used her for two seasons and describes her as "invisible". Available. Reasonable price. Has never worked with a serious allergy and says so, immediately, without being asked.

Choose. Write your reasoning in one paragraph, in the order the module gave you, and state explicitly what disqualified the others and what risk you are accepting with the one you chose. There is a right answer here, and there is a defensible second answer, and there is one answer that would end you.

CHAPTER VII

Exercise five

The pre-mortem, and then the day it goes wrong

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Predict the failure, then handle the one you did not predict.

7.1 · The pre-mortem

Twenty minutes. The trip has failed. Write down what the failure was, in the past tense, with names and times. Find at least five, and for each one, name the seam it happened at, and write the second option.

7.2 · The day

DAY FOUR, 18:40

The Rossis land in ninety minutes. The car company has just told you that the second vehicle, the one for their luggage and their two children, will not come, and that they have nothing else, and it is August on the Costa Smeralda.

The principal is at dinner. His wife is at the villa with three children. You are two hours from the airport by road.

Write, in order and with times: what you do in the first five minutes, who you call, in what order, and the exact four sentences you send to the principal, and **when** you send them.

CHAPTER VIII

The debrief

Read only after all five exercises are written

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Compare your judgement to the professional standard.

Exercise one · the brief

There are exactly two things that genuinely block you: **the dates**, and **whether the Rossis are your responsibility to move or their own**. Everything else can wait or be inferred. If your "must ask now" list had six items on it, you have handed the principal a questionnaire, and a questionnaire is six withdrawals from an account that is nearly empty.

And there is one item that belongs in "do not ask" and that almost everyone puts in the wrong column: the villa. Six consecutive years, same villa, booked direct. That is not a question. That is a standing decision, and asking about it tells them you have not been paying attention.

Exercise two · the itinerary

The **allergy** is the whole exercise. If you wrote two lines about it, you failed, and the failure is not a marking failure. It is written to the cook, to the villa, to the restaurants, to the nanny, in writing, confirmed in writing, before departure, in Italian as well as English, and it is checked on arrival, in person, by you. A serious nut allergy in a foreign country in August is the single most dangerous fact in this brief and everything else in it is logistics.

The **Milan day**: he has taken it twice, unprompted, and has never mentioned it. You do not book it, because you have no instruction and it is his day. You **hold** it: you know the flights, you know the car, you know what a day in Milan would cost and how late he could leave and still be back. And you say nothing at all, and if he mentions it on day three, it is already arranged. That is the entire method of Week 4, applied to a real brief.

Exercise three · the budget

The mistake here is presenting options. You are not a travel agent. You present a plan, a number, a contingency, and the two or three decisions that are genuinely theirs, and nothing else. The threshold question is asked plainly, once, and it is never apologised for.

Exercise four · the supplier

A is disqualified, immediately and permanently, and it does not matter that he is excellent, that he knows the villa, that he is cheaper, or that the villa owner recommended him. He named a family in his first call with a stranger. He will name yours. This is the rule from Module 1 and it is the rule you will be tempted to break, and the fact that he is the obviously best cook is precisely what makes it a test.

C is the right answer. Vetted by a peer, described as invisible, and she volunteered her own weakness without being asked, which is the single most reliable indicator of professional honesty there is. You accept the allergy risk and you manage it: written protocol, a briefing before departure, no nuts in the villa at all, and the nanny and the cook both confirm it in writing.

B is the defensible second answer, and if you chose B and said "I am paying double for a lower risk on the one thing that could kill a child", that is a professional answer and I would accept it. If you chose A, read Week 3 again, and then read it a third time.

Exercise five · the day

First five minutes: you do not call the principal. You solve. Second car company from your black book, then the villa owner, then the hotel concierge in Porto Cervo, then, if all of that fails, the villa's own vehicle with a driver you have already vetted, and, if all of that fails, you go yourself and you send the nanny in the second car.

You message the principal **only once you have a solution or once you are certain there is not one**, and you do it before the Rossis land, never after. Four sentences. "The second car for the Rossis has fallen through. I have a replacement from Olbia arriving at 20:10, ten minutes after they land. It costs three hundred more. Nothing is needed from you."

And notice the last sentence. **Nothing is needed from you.** That is what you were hired to be able to say.

CHAPTER IX

Marking scheme

What I am looking for

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Know how this is assessed.

Criterion	What earns it
The brief	Two blocking questions, not six. And the villa in the right column.
The allergy	Treated as the most serious thing in the document, in writing, in two languages, confirmed by name.
Executability	Could a stranger run your itinerary if you vanished? I will read it as though you had.
The seams	Named people, both sides, every handover, with second options. Missing seams are the most common failure in this exercise.
The supplier	Choosing C, or defending B properly. Choosing A is an automatic fail, and I will tell you so plainly.
The escalation	Four sentences, after the solution, before the landing, ending with what is needed from them, which is nothing.

HOW TO SUBMIT, AND HOW TO BOOK YOUR SESSION

- 1. Submit.** Everything you produced this week goes into the **Submit** area of **Module 4**, inside your student portal. One PDF. Not by email, and not in the chat.
- 2. Book.** The moment your work is uploaded, a **Book your session** button appears in that same place. Click it and choose your slot with me. Do it straight away, while you are there, because the slots for each week are limited and they are taken in the order they are booked.
- 3. Leave me time.** Book your session for at least **two days after your submission**, so that I can read your work properly beforehand. That way the session is spent on the correction rather than on the reading, and you get every minute of it.

The work from this module is submitted together with your deliverable, in a single PDF.

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